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CSC 366: Project Proposal

October 12, 2026

Popular Song Length Over Time

Research Question

How has the average duration of the top 20 songs in the United States changed across decades, from the 1970s through the available 2020s data?

Purpose and Stakeholders

Our project will investigate whether popular songs have become shorter, longer, or remained similar in length over time. Our intended audience includes music producers, artists, music researchers, and music businesses interested in how song length trends may relate to listener preferences and listening behavior. The findings could help them consider song length when planning new releases.

Planned Data Sources

We have selected the MusicBrainz API to collect recording information, including song titles, artists, and available durations. We will also use the iTunes Search API to obtain song durations and supplement missing information. Both sources provide raw JSON data that we can collect and process using Python in Google Colab.

We aim to collect the 20 most popular songs from each of six decades, producing up to 120 unique song records. Before selecting the songs, we will confirm a freely accessible source of historical popularity rankings. The 2020s sample will include only data available by our collection date in 2026.

Preliminary Sources

MusicBrainz. “MusicBrainz API.”
https://musicbrainz.org/doc/MusicBrainz_API

Apple. “iTunes Search API.”
https://performance-partners.apple.com/search-api